

India are Den Networks, Hathway and DigiCable.

A quick comparison

The chief difference between the three different forms of TV viewing lies in the tools they are broadcast through. All three need different kinds of head-end systems. These head-end systems control the entire broadcast and ensure that the signal is encrypted properly. They track users for their viewing needs. The architecture of these head-ends differs completely from each other and their implementation is very specific to technology solution providers like NDS and Nagravision.

The digital television industry is still in its nascent stage in India, with IPTV just being born. Tremendous infrastructural support is needed in order to provide a seamless digital and interactive TV experience to viewers. Digital cable TV and DTH have stabilised over a period of time but IPTV still has to prove its edge over the other two instruments of TV broadcasting.

Digital television broadcasting technology will get more variegated with the advent of personal video recorders (PVRs) and high-definition content. As with every field of life, in the TV viewing domain too, only the fittest will survive.

Points to ponder

Here are a few factors one should consider before subscribing to a particular mode of TV viewing

Uninterrupted signal. This is the most important requirement in TV viewing. Any system is useless if one does not receive a perpetual signal. Signal availability depends on the agency of broadcast. Generally, the least signal interruption occurs in satellite TV as the signal is transported directly from the satellite to the viewer's home. On the other hand, in cable TV, the intermediate area operator's setup faults or failures can cause disturbance in signals—a common occurrence, given the poor power

supply scenario in most parts of India.

The IPTV network also suffers if there is ongoing construction work in the viewer's neighbourhood, resulting in coaxial cable disruptions, which lead to shut-off of the entire triple-play network.

In the case of satellite TV signal, nature plays an important role. Signal outages occur in DTH due to heavy rains, storms, etc. So people who reside in areas prone to heavy rainfalls or storms should not opt for satellite TV.

Customer service. As people need to use different services, easy access to the customer service provided by the broadcaster is a must.

STB software reliability. All receivers (STBs) work using a software, which must be reliable for the STB to function adequately. A thorough review of the product is a must prior to subscription.

Signal quality. Although the quality of audio/video does not differ drastically, noise can get added to cable and IPTV in particular areas, yielding problematic signals.

Network infrastructure. This is the most vital requirement for IPTV. Technically, IPTV requires a large bandwidth to make the TV viewing experience seamless—a facility which is still not available in most parts of India. This situation will only deteriorate further as HDTV channels come into focus.

Services offered. IPTV is more suitable for those who require video on demand quite often. Electronic programme guides (EPGs), flexibility and accuracy also need to be considered.

Cost. Cable TV is still the cheapest option as the already existent network infrastructure is used to deliver these signals. Satellite TV costs higher due to installation and packaging of channels, which vary with each service provider. IPTV can be cost-effective but only if the 'triple play' service is employed. ●

The author is working with a world leading digital television solution provider



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